

In April 1965, fighting began along the border in the Rann of Kutch, Gujarat. Increasing hostilities and a subsequent Pakistani incursion led to full-scale war in September. On 10 September, three locomotive “pilots” and 14 railway constables entered the war zone along the Indo-Pakistan border in Barmer, Rajasthan. They were in a six-wagon train loaded with rations and ammunition meant for the 13th battalion of the Grenadiers who were running short of supplies. The Pakistani Air Force was strafing the area, but the road was riskier. As the train inched forward, it was intercepted at Gadra Road in Barmer, about 3 km from the railway station and bombed. The engine boiler exploded and all 17 men died. Today the spot is a memorial and trains passing by often slow down or stop to pay tribute.

### **Fighting on two borders**

During the 1971 war, the railways serviced the eastern and western border. It ran 2,000 special trains to move forces and equipment; 9,000 members of TA units were mobilized to help with train movement and damage restoration and during the course of their duties in the border areas, 13 railwaymen died, and 26 were wounded. The contribution of the Northern Railway was especially significant, as between October and December, it ran 755 special trains along with 41 ambulance specials, besides others that carried supplies.

The 1033 Railway Engineers, made up of railwaymen from the Western Railway Zone, were despatched to the Barmer, Rajasthan sector, in December 1971. They were to support the Indian forces who had made their way across the border past Khokhrapar, a border town towards Sindh about 6 km inside Pakistan. The assignment was to link the lines between Khokhrapar and Munabao, the last railway station at the Indian border in Rajasthan, to ensure reliable supply of food, water, and ammunition. They did this in 48 hours, despite continuous air raids and strafing and even extended the railway line past the border by 10 km. The first train to Khokhrapar left Munabao on 7 December, less than a week after the war started. For his wartime contribution, a railwayman was awarded the Vir Chakra, a gallantry award. Two others received the Vishisht Seva medals (Special Service medals). Jodhpur’s divisional superintendent and divisional engineer received the Padma Shri, the